

CHARLES BENELLO

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EDUCATION

The University of Chicago

Master of Science in Financial Mathematics

- Wayne Booth Graduate Student Teaching Prize (2026) - UChicago's top graduate teaching award
- Coursework: Options Pricing, Probability & Stochastic Processes, Portfolio & Risk Management, Computing for Finance, ML in Finance

Chicago, IL

Expected Dec 2026

The University of Chicago | GPA: 3.75/4.0

Bachelor of Science in Mathematics and Computer Science (Systems), Minor in Korean

- Coursework: Algorithms, Database Systems, Distributed Systems, Concurrency Control, Operating Systems

Chicago, IL

Jun 2025

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages: Python, Rust, C/C++, SQL, CUDA, TypeScript, Go

Frameworks & Tools: PyTorch, XGBoost, NumPy/Pandas, scikit-learn, Docker, Git, Linux, PostgreSQL, DuckDB, Databricks

Concepts: Options Pricing, Stochastic Processes, Portfolio Optimization, Statistical Modeling, Machine Learning, Distributed Systems, GPU Programming

EXPERIENCE

Quantitative Researcher

Mar 2026 – Present

PayPal (UChicago Project Lab)

Chicago, IL

- Built a self-supervised transaction foundation model (TabBERT-style hierarchical transformer, ~5M params) on 14.5M unlabeled transactions; achieved AUC 0.974 / F1 0.822 on fraud detection at 0.12% positive rate, with focus on probability calibration in the tails.
- Ran 87+ ablations on UChicago's Midway3 SLURM cluster; implemented per-field masking and SPRM from PANTHER (NeurIPS 2025) and PRAGMA (Revolut 2026), with per-field masking yielding +1.9% AUC and +16.8% F1 over baseline.

Software Engineering Intern

Feb 2026 – Present

Alter Domus

Chicago, IL

- Lifted document extraction accuracy from 50% to 92–97% by architecting a multi-stage pipeline with schema-enforced structured output and cross-reference verification for 100+ page financial filings.
- Built an LLM-as-a-Judge evaluation framework for faithfulness, numerical accuracy, and completeness; cut LLM inference costs by optimizing context handling.

Quantitative Researcher

Oct – Dec 2025

Bank of America (UChicago Project Lab)

Chicago, IL

- Built an AI-driven platform to rebalance high-quality liquid asset portfolios, generating trade recommendations that minimize risk under capital, liquidity, and net interest income constraints.
- Engineered a multi-agent LLM debate system where competing agents generate macro stress scenarios and produce probability-weighted reallocation recommendations.

Database Research Assistant

Apr 2023 – Present

ChiData Research Lab, University of Chicago

Chicago, IL

- First-authored VLDB 2026 paper by designing a parallel external merge sort in Rust that completes under tight memory budgets where PostgreSQL, DuckDB, and ClickHouse abort.
- Sole-authored HPTS 2026 paper on a lightweight prediction model for sort configuration on cloud and disaggregated hardware, transferring calibration across machines within 3–5% of optimal.

GPU Systems Researcher

Jun – Sep 2025

EPFL (DIAS Lab)

Lausanne, Switzerland

- Cut out-of-memory query times by 50–200% by engineering a macroblock-based GPU decompression strategy in CUDA/C++ for large analytical workloads.

PROJECTS

Transit Coverage Optimizer | Python | [cmbenello.github.io/covtsp](https://github.com/cmbenello/covtsp)

2026

- Beat the Guinness World Record by 60 minutes (16h45m vs. 17h45m) by building a Covering TSP solver on a time-expanded graph (160K nodes, 1.26M edges) with k-NN and epsilon-greedy search; generalized to NYC and Berlin.

Relational Database Engine | Rust | github.com/cmbenello/CrustyDB

2023

- Implemented a multi-threaded relational database from scratch: B+ tree indexing, concurrent buffer pool with page-level locking, heap storage, and a SQL query execution engine.

PUBLICATIONS

[1] R. Otaki*, C. Benello*, et al. "CrocSort: Resource-Efficient, Skew-Resilient Parallel External Merge Sort." *VLDB 2026*. (*Equal contribution)

[2] C. Benello. "Getting the Most Out of External Sorting in Cloud and Disaggregated Environments." *HPTS 2026*.

[3] R. Otaki, J.H. Chang, C. Benello, A. Elmore, G. Graefe. "Resource-Adaptive Query Execution." *CIDR 2025*.

ADDITIONAL

Citizenship: US, UK, Italy | **Languages:** Korean, Italian (Intermediate); French (Basic) | **Interests:** Running (Chicago Marathon '22, '23, '24), Climbing